

THESIS SCHEDULE**Fall Semester**

Below is an approximate outline of expectations for the fall 2025 semester – precise due dates will be determined by your advisor. The goals of the fall semester include preparation of a preliminary annotated bibliography, literature review, identification of data sources and methods, IRB (institutional review board) submission, and a draft thesis proposal. Students also should confirm a Reader towards the end of the fall semester.

Monday, 8/18	Submit topic(s) of your interest and choices of advisor via Google Form
Wednesday, 9/3	First class, large group meeting followed by sub-group meetings
Wednesday, 10/8	IRB information session (via Zoom) Tentative
Tuesday, 11/25	Target date for submitting full IRB materials
Wednesday, 12/10	Thesis proposal submission
Wednesday, 12/17	Reader Approval Form submission
	Submit to UP Office the form signed by the Reader(s) agreeing to serve as the Reader(s) and that they have read and approved the general terms of the thesis proposal. All GSAPP faculty/adjuncts and Columbia faculty are eligible to act as a Reader. Reader(s) from outside of Columbia University must be approved by the thesis advisor.

Winter Break

Students are expected to use the break to collect data and begin the research phase of their theses.

Spring Semester

Students hold meetings with their advisor on an as-needed basis. Finalize IRB approval if needed in January.

Monday, March 30	Penultimate Draft due to Advisor and schedule Thesis Jury with permission of Advisor
April 13-17	Thesis Jury Week – Required for Graduation Thesis Juries with student, advisor, and reader. The reader(s) must receive a copy of the draft thesis no fewer than 14 days before the jury date. Failure to submit the draft in a timely manner is cause for cancellation of the jury review. A successful jury is required for a passing grade in the course.
Friday, May 8	Complete final edits to thesis based on comments received at jury. Final copy due to advisor for grading.
Monday, May 11	A digital copy of your thesis saved as a PDF and abstract as a .txt or .rtf file that includes your name, the title and advisors name should be dropped off to Leigh in the Urban Planning Office. In addition, before submitting your thesis, you will be required to sign an agreement form acknowledging that your thesis will be archived on-line. You will have the right to keep your thesis closed to public viewing for up to two years. This form should be saved as a PDF and included on your media storage with the copy of your thesis and abstract for submission.

THESIS GUIDELINES

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I. What Is the Thesis?

The thesis is an essential part of the urban planning curriculum. It is an individual investigation of the student's own choice that is supervised closely by a faculty member of the Urban Planning Program. It is intended to demonstrate the student's ability to structure an argument about an issue or problem significant or clearly relevant to planning practice, planning thought, and/or the planning profession. Structuring an effective argument is the process of organizing and making a compelling and logical case for an idea, theory, testable hypothesis, policy position, or empirical finding. In research, this involves gathering and analyzing evidence in a systematic way.

The thesis is the culmination of the two-year course of study and should demonstrate a synthetic understanding of the professional skills and substantive knowledge bases, which form the content of the curriculum of the Urban Planning Program.

While the particular form and components of the argument will vary depending on the problem being addressed, some basic steps are common. These include:

1. Defining a problem as a conceptually (logically) ordered set of questions, each of which will need to be answered or addressed;
2. Developing knowledge of the relevant bodies of theory, concept, and methods, and of previously performed empirical research;
3. Judging the validity of this literature;
4. Identifying the most appropriate methods of evidence or data collection for answering the questions;
5. Qualitatively and/or quantitatively analyzing or evaluating the available evidence;
6. Organizing the evidence to produce findings;

7. Writing in a clear, coherent, and succinct style so that we can follow your argument; and
8. Drawing implications from your findings, thus contributing a better understanding of the problem and/or pointing the way toward improving existing practice.

The program gives two thesis/capstone awards at graduation: Charles Abrams Thesis Award (for a thesis that best exemplifies a commitment to social justice) and Honor Award for Excellence in Urban Planning (for a thesis/capstone of high overall quality).

II. The Scope of the Thesis

1. While the “proper” length of the thesis varies for different topics, a normal length for a well-specified topic should typically be between 50 and 75 double-spaced, typewritten pages of text. The bibliography and appendices (where relevant) are additional pages.
2. You should work closely with your advisor at the early stages to focus your topic and to select a topic within your ability and the time allowed for completion. Reviewing past work will help you get a sense of the topics, scope and methodologies that other students have chosen. Our program website contains a list of thesis titles since 2008, and you can locate their full texts through [Columbia Academic Commons](#).
3. The topic of the thesis can come from a wide variety of subject areas but **you should select a topic within your concentration** (Built Environment, Community and Economic Development, International Planning and Development, and Urban Analytics). It can be in functional areas of planning (e.g., housing, economic development, health planning, transportation), focus on a particular geographic area, or address a particular aspect of planning thought or method. The research design can be a case study, a comparative analysis, a mathematical model, a program evaluation, or a statistical assessment. The student should work closely with their advisor, to choose the most appropriate design for that particular topic. In general, a thesis consisting of only a review of existing literature in a certain topical area is unacceptable. On the other hand, doing extensive original research is well beyond the acceptable thesis standards at the Master’s degree level.
4. Thesis students will meet as a whole at the start of the fall semester and then break into smaller groups to work with their faculty advisor. In the spring semester, students will meet with the advisor on an as-needed basis and will be submitting drafts of the thesis on a regular basis.

III. Writing the Proposal

In the fall semester, each student will write a thesis proposal. The research design specified by the proposal will be implemented in the spring semester.

The following should be observed in writing a proposal:

1. A succinct statement of the problem(s) or issue(s) being addressed;
2. A statement of the significance or relevance of the problem(s);

3. A set of logically ordered questions that follow from the problem statement and need to be answered;
4. Presentation of the background to the problem;
5. A review of the pertinent literature;
6. Techniques, data sources, methods, and a research design that will be used to answer the questions;
7. A listing of the most important bibliographic references;
8. An outline of tentative chapter headings – substantive headings are strongly encouraged; and
9. A timetable for conducting the key research and writing tasks.

In general, a proposal should not exceed 20 double-spaced pages.

IV. The Thesis Advisor

1. Each student will be assigned a thesis advisor to supervise the progress of the work. The thesis advisor will be a faculty member of the Urban Planning Program. In special cases, other faculty members within Columbia University may be used.
2. The thesis advisor's responsibilities are:
 - a. to help a student develop a topic—to define its scope and focus on key issues or questions to be addressed;
 - b. to aid in research and provide research resources;
 - c. to provide advice and judgment on theoretical and methodological problems which might arise;
 - d. to review and provide written comments on drafts of the chapters;
 - e. to guide the preparation of the jury presentation; and
 - f. to conduct the student's jury, review subsequent revisions, assign a grade, and supervise the final completion and submission of the thesis.
3. It is expected that the student will work closely with their advisor. This means weekly meetings during the fall term and at least every two weeks during the spring term. Keep in mind that the advisor has to be satisfied that in their judgment the penultimate draft is at least adequate to pass the thesis jury.
4. The thesis advisor must be given ample time to review drafts and to make written comments, in most cases about a week. Do not expect overnight feedback.

V. The Thesis Reader

1. The minimum required responsibility of readers is to read the penultimate draft of your thesis or capstone project and attend your 1-hour jury review in April. Additional engagement is at the discretion of you and your reader.
2. All students must have at least 1 reader. Students cannot have more than 2 readers.
3. Readers must be appointed by GSAPP to officially serve as your reader. Readers may not do work pro bono. You can let your potential readers know that each is paid \$300.
4. Thesis/Capstone Reader Selection Guidelines

There are important restrictions regarding reader appointment and compensation. When intended readers do not meet the appointment requirements below or may require additional confirmation by the Dean's Office, students should contact the UP Program Office well in advance, preferably before the deadline for submitting your reader agreement form (December 17, 2025).

a. Columbia University Readers

- i. Readers can be current members of the UP faculty or other faculty members at GSAPP.
- ii. Readers can be faculty (but not officers of research) in other schools at the University, however, we will need to confirm on a case-by-case basis.
- iii. Barnard or Teachers College faculty cannot be readers.
- iv. Faculty who have not worked at the University recently, are considered as an outside reader.
- v. Certain types of researchers at the University—even if they serve as faculty—cannot be readers. The Dean's Office will need to verify on a case-by-case basis.

b. Outside Readers

- i. Outside readers must be United States citizens or have a green card that permits them to work in the United States, and should hold at least a master's degree.
- ii. Outside readers must reside within the United States when serving as the reader.
- iii. Readers need to complete a Form I-9 by visiting (in person) one of the University's I-9 centers before February 2, 2026. Readers based outside the NYC area may visit one of the I-9 Anywhere centers located throughout the country. [Here are I-9 instructions that you can share with your readers.](#) Their appointment start date will be March 1, 2026. (They will need to know this date when completing the I-9 verification process.)
- iv. If your reader does not complete the I-9 verification process and appointment paperwork by February 2, you will need to identify a replacement reader.

5. Reader Form Submission Process

Please discuss all of the above with your advisor so that you can find the best official readers. Once your proposal is ready (or almost ready), share it with your reader and get their agreement by signing the Reader Approval Form. You need to send the signed form by email to Leigh in the Urban Planning Office (lb663@columbia.edu). It's important to submit your signed Reader Approval Form promptly so that the readers can be appointed by the University to help you in the Spring semester. The Dean's office will be reaching out to your readers via email for appointment purposes.

VI. The Thesis Jury

1. A complete draft of the thesis must be presented to a thesis jury for review and advice. Thesis juries typically take place in the second or third week of April.
2. The jury consists of at least two jury members: a thesis advisor and a reader.
3. The student must contact all jury members to ascertain their availability to meet. It is the student's responsibility to arrange a date and time by completing and submitting a Thesis Jury Sign-up Form (signed by your advisor) to Leigh in the Urban Planning Office.
4. The student must distribute the required number of copies (one for each member of the jury) of the thesis to the jury members at least **two weeks** prior to the scheduled jury date. Juries cannot be scheduled until the faculty advisor has received this draft and approved it for a jury.
5. At the thesis jury, each student will give a 10-12 minute oral summary of their thesis (audio-visual aids may be used), covering the following points:
 - a. the purpose and significance of the thesis;
 - b. what the argument is and how it has been studied; and
 - c. the major conclusions and implications that can be drawn: e.g., recommendations for new programs, legislation, policy, techniques, procedures, allocations, theories, information, or institutional changes.
6. The thesis jury will vote to either:
 - a. approve and pass the thesis as it is (or with minor revisions);
 - b. withhold approval until major revisions are made (the thesis jury has the option of asking for another jury or allowing the advisor or another member of the jury to make final approval; without holding another jury); or
 - c. not approve the thesis.
7. If revisions are required, a list of these will be recorded by the thesis advisor and given to the student immediately after the jury. This list will be the basis for the approval of the revised thesis. The student should submit minor revisions on the date recorded on the thesis form.
8. The student will graduate as long as he or she receives a **Passing** grade. In order to graduate, the student must submit one copy of the thesis to the advisor for grading and one digital copy with signed agreement form to Leigh in the Urban Planning Office to be digitally archived.

VI. Institutional Review Board

All university-based projects involving human subjects must be submitted in proposal form (also known as protocol) to the University's Institutional Review Board (IRB). The general purpose is to prevent human subjects from harm. Approval must be attained prior to field research.

VII. Format and Style Advice

1. References

You must cite all of the sources you use in preparing your thesis. Any ideas that are not your own or not common knowledge should be referenced. Presenting ideas that are not your own without properly citing the sources is plagiarism and a serious academic offense.

You can use the author-date system described in the [Chicago-Style Citation Quick Guide](#). If a different reference style is used, please use it consistently throughout the thesis.

2. Footnotes

Because you are using the author-date system to cite your references, footnotes should be used only to

- a. amplify discussion beyond the text, and
- b. provide cross-reference to related parts of the thesis.

Footnote form should be **consistent**. Above all, footnotes are a form of communication with readers, enabling them to check with ease. Footnotes should be prepared using the format specified in Kate L. Turabian, *A Manual for Writers of Term Papers, Theses, and Dissertations*, latest edition. Students are strongly urged to use the format even in the writing of draft chapters.

3. Graphic and Tabulated Materials

Graphic and tabulated materials should be placed as close to the text reference as possible. These materials should have appropriate numbers and titles, with source(s) of information indicated. Scales and north arrows should be indicated on all maps and drawings when applicable. The numbers of graphic and tabulated materials should be cross-referenced in the text.

4. Cover: the form of the cover must follow the example in the Appendix.

5. Abstract

The page following the cover page will include a short (one page or less) abstract or summary of the thesis. The abstract should include the thesis title, thesis question, the research design and the key findings. Please also send a copy of your thesis abstract as a .txt or .rtf file that includes the title and advisors name to Leigh, the Urban Planning Program Assistant (lb663@columbia.edu). The abstract may be posted on the web to help future generations of students and scholars around the world identify more precisely the contents of your thesis before they read the full version on Columbia Academic Commons.

6. Organization

The final thesis should be assembled in the order below:

- Cover page (including title, your name, degree fulfillment line, school, year, advisor/reader names)
- Abstract
- Acknowledgments (optional)
- Table of contents, with page numbers
- List of tables (if applicable), with page numbers
- List of figures (if applicable), with page numbers
- Text (main body of thesis)
- Appendix or appendices (if applicable), with titles and page numbers
- Bibliography

7. Spacing and Margins

All text material and preliminary pages, including the abstract, should be **double-spaced**. Notes, bibliographic references, and long quotations may be single-spaced. The document should be arranged as if it were to be single-sided. All margins should be one full inch.

8. Pagination

The cover page should be lowercase Roman numeral “i” but not typed. Subsequent pages should be typed as “ii, iii,” etc., until the thesis proper is reached. **The first page of the thesis proper is Arabic “1”** and each chapter should start on a new page. Pagination appears within the one-inch margin.

VIII. Policy for Students with an Incomplete Thesis

The thesis for the Master of Science in Urban Planning is the centerpiece of your education, and should reflect the thought and rigor that makes it, literally, your “master” piece. Following University policy, a student who fails to finish their thesis by the required due date they will be given an “F”, a grade that erases the credit for that course. In this case the thesis can only be completed if the student re-registers and pays for the required thesis course. The only exception is when there is a documented medical issue or extenuating circumstances that have been approved by the GSAPP Student Affairs Office, in which case you would be given a CP (Credit Pending) or INC (Incomplete) and would be given an extension of time to complete your thesis.

Registration must take place the week prior to each semester – in other words, in the week preceding Labor Day for the fall semester, and in the week preceding the Martin Luther King holiday for the spring semester. Students register and pay the current tuition rate for the thesis course that is missing.

Prior to re-registering to complete your thesis, you must contact your advisor and Urban Planning Program Director to discuss your thesis. You should have a clear idea of your methodology and timeline for completion before you register, so you are certain you can complete your work in the semester in which you are paying tuition. You will continue to coordinate with your chosen advisor and reader(s) and will be required to hold a thesis jury prior to receiving your final grade.

IX. Digital Thesis Guidelines

Theses produced for the Master of Science in Urban Planning are submitted in digital form to the Urban Planning Program and to Columbia Academic Commons, the University's digital research repository. More information about Academic Commons at Columbia University can be found here:

<http://academiccommons.columbia.edu/>

This requirement does not eliminate any responsibility for the student to provide paper review copies as requested by advisor and reader(s).

Requirements for Submission

Students are required to submit their thesis and abstract as separate documents, thesis should be saved as a .pdf document, and abstracts as .txt. or .rtf file to the Urban Planning Office. Each file should be clearly labeled as shown below:

Thesis (Please save as a .pdf document)

LastnameFirstname_GSAPPUP_2026_Thesis

Abstract (Please save abstracts as a separate .txt or .rtf file that includes title and advisors name)

LastnameFirstname_GSAPPUP_2026_Abstract

Theses may be delivered via email or sent through cloud storage, or if the file is too large it can be brought to the Urban Planning office to be manually uploaded.

Signed Author Agreement Form

Students must include a signed agreement form permitting the thesis to be digitally archived through Columbia Academic Commons. Students have the right to keep their thesis closed from public view for one or two years (this option is on the form). This option is generally used by students who wish to publish their thesis material.

The program will deliver all theses to Columbia Academic Commons and upon receipt, they will assign a permanent URL to each thesis. This will allow a link to the full thesis from the GSAPP website as well as for the library catalog. The theses will be located and accessed via the Internet; there will be "universal access" to this material (i.e., it will not be restricted to those with a Columbia UNI/log-in).

Where student work incorporates the intellectual property of other authors and creators their copyright needs to be respected and credited – this is especially important because your work will be readily available on the internet and rights-holders can easily identify where their work has been cited or reproduced. For additional information about utilizing copyrighted material within your thesis, please visit the webpage of Columbia's Copyright Advisory Office: <https://copyright.columbia.edu/>.

APPENDIX: SAMPLE TITLE PAGE

[YOUR THESIS TITLE]

A Thesis Presented to the Faculty of Architecture, Planning and Preservation
COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY

In Partial Fulfillment
of the Requirements for the Degree
Master of Science in Urban Planning

by

[YOUR NAME]

May 2026